

Home Mold Risk Assessment

20-Point Room-by-Room Checklist + Severity Guide + Location Diagnostic

This checklist helps you systematically assess mold and damp risk across your home. It does not replace a professional inspection — it gives you the information to have a better conversation when you need one. You need: a torch, a hygrometer (€15–40 at any hardware store), and 30 minutes.

HUMIDITY — AIR MOISTURE READINGS

- ☐ Hygrometer in main bedroom — read over 5 days, note min/max
Target: consistently below 65% RH in winter
- ☐ Hygrometer in living room — read over 5 days
Target: below 65% RH in winter
- ☐ Bathroom: time to return below 65% RH after shower
Should reach <65% within 30–60 min with active extractor fan

HYGROMETER REFERENCE	Under 60% RH	60–70% RH	70–80% RH	Over 80% RH
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BEDROOM(S)

- ☐ Upper corners of all exterior walls
Most common condensation zone — check with torch, especially in winter
- ☐ Behind and at sides of all wardrobes against exterior walls
Pull wardrobe 30cm from wall, check back panel AND the wall surface
- ☐ Window frames and inner sills
Aluminium / iron frames without thermal break are high risk
- ☐ Skirting boards along exterior walls
Dark staining rising from floor level = possible rising damp
- ☐ Ceiling near exterior wall junctions in older buildings

BATHROOM

- ☐ Tile grout — especially floor-to-wall angle
Black discolouration in grout = Cladosporium or Aspergillus niger
- ☐ Silicone seal of shower or bath
Pink/black discolouration — surface mold, manageable if caught early
- ☐ Ceiling and upper corners
Mold here = ventilation problem, not just surface moisture
- ☐ Window frame and inner sill
- ☐ Inside under-sink cabinet
Smell + mold inside = check pipe joints for slow drip

KITCHEN

- ☐ Silicone seal between worktop and wall
Frequent mold zone — food residue + moisture
- ☐ Inside wall-adjacent cabinets, especially above refrigerator
Open and check back panel and interior walls
- ☐ Wall behind refrigerator
Refrigerator keeps wall cold → condensation → mold
- ☐ Skirting board near sink
- ☐ Note: extractor fan — does it exhaust to outside?
Recirculating hoods remove grease but NOT moisture from cooking

LIVING AREAS & COMMUNAL SPACES

- ☐ Ceiling — circular or irregular yellowish/grey-brown patches
Circular patch = water infiltrating from roof or terrace above
- ☐ Exterior wall skirting boards on ground floor
Dark staining rising from floor = rising damp
- ☐ Paint blistering or flaking on specific sections of exterior walls
Localised blistering = moisture trapped behind the paint layer
- ☐ Any wall that feels persistently cool or damp to touch

BASEMENT / GARAGE / STORAGE (if accessible)

- ☐ Efflorescence on masonry walls — white or grey mineral deposits
Not mold, but direct evidence of water moving through the wall
- ☐ Mold on structural timber
- ☐ Persistent musty smell without visible mold
Hidden mold behind cladding or in structural materials — inspection needed
- ☐ Water level marks on walls — horizontal discolouration lines
Evidence of past flooding or seasonal water ingress

WHAT DID YOU FIND? — Severity Guide

LEVEL	SITUATION	ACTION
1 MONITOR	Visible mold <0.1 m ² on non-porous surface. RH 60–70%. No mold smell. No health symptoms.	Improve ventilation. Physical removal. Monitor recurrence.
2 FIND SOURCE	Mold 0.1–1 m ² , OR returns <6 weeks, OR RH consistently >70%, OR mold smell without visible mold.	Identify and fix moisture source before all else.
3 INSPECTION	Mold >1 m ² , OR on porous materials, OR shiny/slimy appearance, OR household member has symptoms that improve away from home.	Independent professional inspection recommended.
4 PROFESSIONAL ONLY	Significant water damage, suspected hidden mold with severe health symptoms, or mold in central HVAC system.	Do not intervene without professional support.

LOCATION → CAUSE DIAGNOSTIC

MOLD LOCATION	MOST LIKELY CAUSE	WHAT YOU NEED
Upper wall corners	Condensation — poor ventilation	Improve ventilation
Window frames & sills	Thermal bridge in frame profile	Better insulation or new windows
Behind furniture at exterior walls	Condensation, no air circulation	Move furniture, check insulation
Rising from skirting board (ground floor)	Rising damp / capillary action	Specialist structural diagnosis
Isolated patch after heavy rain	Water infiltration	Find and seal entry point
Inside under-sink cabinet	Active or old plumbing leak	Check all pipe connections
Circular ceiling patch	Roof or terrace water infiltration	Roof inspection
Inside wardrobe back panel	Condensation in unventilated space	Move wardrobe, ventilate space

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This checklist is for educational purposes and does not replace professional medical or technical advice. For the full room-by-room guide, species information, and health articles, visit moldcheck.pt